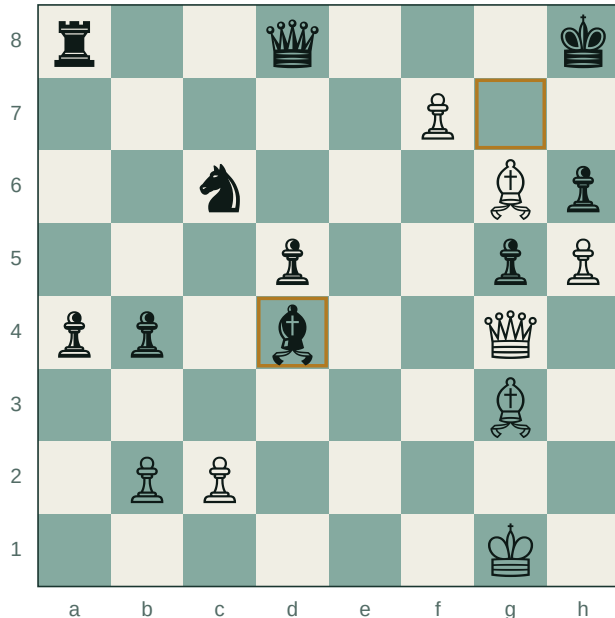


Mate in three: White, move 40

Mate in three

White to move



Previous move: 39...Bxd4+. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

40. Qxd4+ Nxd4 41. Be5+ Qf6 42. Bxf6#

40.Qxd4+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on d4. Recorded reply: **40...Nxd4.**

41.Be5+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. From e5 it attacks king on h8 and knight on d4. Recorded reply: **41...Qf6.**

42.Bxf6# Mate: bishop on f6 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Bishop on f6. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: knight on c6. Check for tactical protection.